

SMALL BUSINESS WORKBOOK

AI Readiness Checklist

Find out where AI can save your team time, reduce costs, and improve results.

**35 questions. 7 readiness areas.
One practical starting plan.**

For founders, small-business owners, agencies, and growing teams exploring responsible, useful AI adoption.

AI readiness is not about having the newest tools.

It is about having the right problems, information, processes, people, and safeguards in place so AI creates value instead of extra work.

How to score each statement

0**NOT YET**

This is missing, unclear, or not currently practiced.

1**PARTLY**

Some pieces exist, but the practice is inconsistent or incomplete.

2**YES**

This is clear, documented, owned, and practiced consistently.

IMPORTANT This is a planning tool, not legal, cybersecurity, financial, HR, or compliance advice. Sensitive and high-impact uses require qualified review and appropriate controls.

Goals & Business Priorities

AI works best when it is tied to a real business outcome, not used simply because it is available.

STATEMENT	0	1	2
We can name the top three business problems we want AI to help solve.	☐	☐	☐
We know which results matter most: time saved, lower cost, faster response, more sales, or better quality.	☐	☐	☐
We have at least one repetitive, high-volume workflow suitable for a small AI pilot.	☐	☐	☐
We can identify an owner who will be accountable for the pilot.	☐	☐	☐
We have a realistic definition of success for the first 30–60 days.	☐	☐	☐

SCORING 0 = Not yet • 1 = Partly / inconsistently • 2 = Yes / consistently

SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

Processes & Time Drains

Clear, repeatable processes are easier to improve. AI cannot reliably fix a workflow nobody understands.

STATEMENT	0	1	2
Our recurring workflows are documented or can be explained step by step.	☐	☐	☐
We know where employees spend the most time on repetitive work.	☐	☐	☐
We can identify bottlenecks, delays, duplicate work, or frequent handoff problems.	☐	☐	☐
The tasks we want to improve have consistent inputs and expected outputs.	☐	☐	☐
We know which steps require human judgment, approval, or relationship-building.	☐	☐	☐

SCORING 0 = Not yet • 1 = Partly / inconsistently • 2 = Yes / consistently

SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

Data & Business Knowledge

Useful AI depends on useful information. Organized, accurate source material creates more reliable results.

STATEMENT	0	1	2
Our key documents, templates, FAQs, and policies are current and easy to find.	☐	☐	☐
Customer and operational data is reasonably accurate and consistently entered.	☐	☐	☐
We know which information is confidential, sensitive, regulated, or restricted.	☐	☐	☐
We have permission to use the data required for the proposed AI workflow.	☐	☐	☐
We can identify an approved source of truth for the AI to reference.	☐	☐	☐

SCORING 0 = Not yet • 1 = Partly / inconsistently • 2 = Yes / consistently

SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

Technology & Integration

A good AI tool must fit the systems your team already uses, or the new process will create more work.

STATEMENT	0	1	2
We have an up-to-date list of the software and platforms our team uses.	☐	☐	☐
Our core tools support integrations, automations, exports, or secure API access where needed.	☐	☐	☐
We understand where information must move between systems.	☐	☐	☐
We can test a new tool without disrupting critical business operations.	☐	☐	☐
We have someone who can configure, maintain, or coordinate technical setup.	☐	☐	☐

SCORING 0 = Not yet • 1 = Partly / inconsistently • 2 = Yes / consistently

SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

Team Readiness & Ownership

AI adoption is a people project. Teams need clear expectations, training, and a safe way to flag problems.



STATEMENT	0	1	2
Leadership can explain why the business is exploring AI and what it is meant to improve.	☐	☐	☐
Employees are encouraged to identify repetitive tasks and improvement opportunities.	☐	☐	☐
The team understands that AI output must be reviewed before important use.	☐	☐	☐
We can provide training, examples, and written usage guidelines.	☐	☐	☐
There is a clear person responsible for questions, feedback, and ongoing improvement.	☐	☐	☐

SCORING 0 = Not yet • 1 = Partly / inconsistently • 2 = Yes / consistently

SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

Privacy, Security & Risk

Responsible use protects your customers, your team, and your reputation.

STATEMENT	0	1	2
We have rules for what employees may and may not enter into public AI tools.	☐	☐	☐
We review tool privacy terms, data retention, access controls, and vendor permissions.	☐	☐	☐
High-risk outputs — legal, financial, HR, health, or safety-related — require qualified human review.	☐	☐	☐
We can trace important outputs back to their source information or reviewer.	☐	☐	☐
We have a process to report, correct, and learn from inaccurate or inappropriate AI output.	☐	☐	☐

SCORING 0 = Not yet • 1 = Partly / inconsistently • 2 = Yes / consistently

SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

Customer Experience & Quality

Speed only creates value when the result is accurate, useful, and still feels like your business.

STATEMENT	0	1	2
We know which customer interactions may use AI and which should remain human-led.	☐	☐	☐
We have a defined brand voice, quality standard, or approved response library.	☐	☐	☐
A human reviews customer-facing content when accuracy or nuance matters.	☐	☐	☐
Customers can reach a person when an automated response does not solve the issue.	☐	☐	☐
We can track quality, satisfaction, response time, conversion, or another outcome after launch.	☐	☐	☐

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SECTION SCORE ____ / 10

●YOUR RESULTS

Calculate your AI readiness score.

Transfer each section score below. Add them together for a total out of 70.

READINESS AREA	YOUR SCORE	MAXIMUM
Goals & Business Priorities	.	10
Processes & Time Drains	.	10
Data & Business Knowledge	.	10
Technology & Integration	.	10
Team Readiness & Ownership	.	10
Privacy, Security & Risk	.	10
Customer Experience & Quality	.	10
TOTAL READINESS SCORE		70

●WHAT YOUR SCORE SUGGESTS

0–20 — FOUNDATION FIRST

Choose one business problem, document the workflow, clean up the source information, and create basic AI-use rules before investing in tools.

21–40 — READY FOR A CONTROLLED PILOT

You have useful building blocks. Select one low-risk, repetitive workflow and run a measured 30-day test with human review.

41–55 — READY TO SCALE SELECTIVELY

Several areas are strong. Standardize what works, connect tools carefully, train the team, and expand only where results are measurable.

56–70 — STRONG AI-READY FOUNDATION

Your business is positioned for broader adoption. Focus on governance, integrations, portfolio-level measurement, and continuous improvement.

●YOUR OPPORTUNITY MAP

Where could AI create value first?

Check the workflows that are frequent, time-consuming, and low-risk enough to test. Do not automate a broken process; clarify it first.

☐ ADMIN	Meeting summaries; inbox triage; document formatting; data cleanup; internal search
☐ MARKETING	Content ideas; first drafts; repurposing; research summaries; basic image briefs
☐ SALES	Lead research; CRM notes; call summaries; follow-up drafts; proposal preparation
☐ CUSTOMER SUPPORT	FAQ drafts; ticket classification; response suggestions; knowledge-base search
☐ OPERATIONS	SOP drafts; status summaries; task extraction; quality checks; workflow documentation
☐ FINANCE SUPPORT	Invoice reminders; receipt extraction; variance flags; report explanations — with human review

●CHOOSE ONE 30-DAY PILOT

WORKFLOW	
CURRENT PAIN	
AI-ASSISTED CHANGE	
HUMAN REVIEW	
SUCCESS METRIC	

●READY WHEN YOU ARE

AI should take work off your plate — not add another system to manage.

The best results come from pairing smart tools with clear processes and reliable people. VIA VA helps growing businesses add skilled virtual support for the work around AI: research, documentation, data organization, content preparation, CRM updates, customer follow-up, quality checks, and more.

Start with one useful workflow. Keep a human in the loop. Measure what changes.

Build a Smarter Support System

viavateam.com

Vetted & interviewed • Dedicated support • Month-to-month • Free rematch